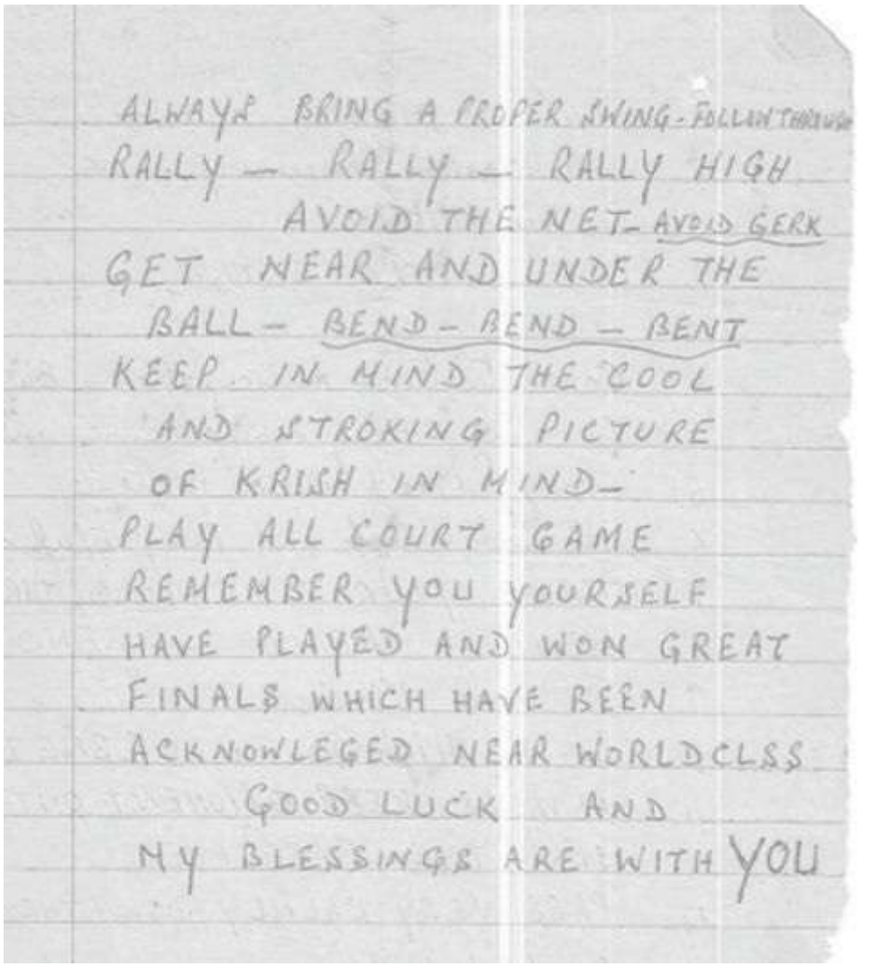


However, despite her grit and tenacity, Kiran succumbs to gamesmanship. She is always willing to accept your side of the story till you yourself prove it wrong. She herself would rather take things at face value. For instance, in the Northern India tennis championships of 1972, she was playing a six-foot-two Australian in the finals. Kiran led 6-3, 3-1. At rest periods during changeovers, the Australian would wrinkle up her face and let Kiran see her tears and Kiran got round to trying to buck her up. Her father, sensing what was going on, went to Kiran and scolded her. Immediately, the Australian complained to the umpire that Kiran was being coached. Kiran lost the match 6-3, 3-6, 4-6. She was ashamed of herself that evening and had a hearty cry.

The very next week she was pitted against the same opponent in the Punjab State championships at Chandigarh. This time she did not speak a word to her opponent and just let her racket do the talking. Kiran beat her 6-0, 6-0. She lost her gold chain while playing that match but that certainly was of no consequence at this sweet moment of revenge.

Kiran became the national junior champion at the age of sixteen, seven years after she was initiated into tennis by her father. She was a tanned and scrawny kid who would tie her hair in tight plaits, or a pony tail, to keep it from blocking her vision. It bothered her to have her hair shampooed every day and to tie and braid it. So one day she just ran across to the barber's and made him chop it off to the style she sports to date: what she was told was called the 'boy cut'.

She played her first tournament outside Amritsar at the age of fourteen. This was the national championship for the year 1964– 65, held at the Delhi Gymkhana courts. Om Prakash, the son of the gardener at the courts she played in at Amritsar, accompanied her on her maiden venture. (Om later became a tennis coach and did considerably well for himself.) At the Delhi Gymkhana courts, dressed